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Enterprise level

At the enterprise level Flash and Flex are being used to create engaging client-server applications, web applications, CRM applications and financial services applications that help businesses bring a new level of interactivity for their customers. "Almost everyone is talking about creating compelling user experiences. Companies themselves are investing a lot in generating this kind of a user experience for their customers – take for instance Harley Davidson or Allen Solly – they've made their web experience fully in line with their brand and what it stands for. Flash is indeed letting them engage better with their customers," says Prabhjeet Singh, Country Marketing Head, Adobe Systems India.

Adobe Flash is the front end for these applications while you have a lot of application logic code sitting behind the animation or motion you see on your screen. Flex takes care of this server side communication and loading data from databases etc. Designing at the enterprise level happens at three levels. First is the usability and interface design side, which requires a person with knowledge of data architecture on the web, someone who can create a good menu layout and pageflow etc. The second part is designing the prototypes which requires Photoshop and Flash based animation designers who create movable designs. The third is writing of the business code, connecting it to the server side, working with the database logic etc which is done by the Flex developers. Different organisations use different sets of people or they use one person for all three. Companies, usually outsourcing units, who are into building these kinds of applications require people with an Engineering or MCA type of background with good programming ability. "For Flex candidates, we have a written test for assessing knowledge and programming ability, and we also look at previous work, if they have any. Then technical interviews follow where problems on Business Logic are asked and candidates have to come up with the thought process for a solution. Similarly we test creativity for Flash candidates by giving them a particular component and ask them how they could make it look better," said Sandeep Dasgupta, Director-Engineering, Tavant Technologies.

Freshers can expect anywhere between three to five lakhs per annum. At the Architect or Technology Lead level it's even more difficult to find the right people, so the premium goes as high as 50 to 100 percent over a similar Java person. These are technologies that are at the most three to five years old. So when you're asking for an Architect with 10 plus years of experience, you're assuming that at least five would be spent on Flash or Flex. Not many companies or individuals made the switch in the early days. Architects oversee design, program architecture, ensure code quality is good, and mentor programmers. The take away at this level ranges from ₹14 lacs pa all the way upto ₹30 lacs p.a.



"The premise that HTML5 will eventually replace Flash to me is a myth. We're comparing what Flash already did some time back to what HTML5 is only promising to do."

Himanshu Mody CEO Tekno Point Multimedia

The HTML5 debate

Reams have been written about this subject and everyone is waiting with bated breath to see the outcome. If indeed HTML5 will let you do many of the things Flash can, it's not a stretch of imagination to think of the eventual questions – Will Flash be phased out? Will Flash developers be left redundant? If so, can they transition to the new standard? – The industry opinion seems to be unanimously similar. "It is a step in the right direction. HTML 4 didn't support a lot of functions, you had a lot of add on components being done like XML, XHTML, XForms etc. So HTML5 is a right step towards taking everything back into the standard hyper text model. Having said that it is still evolving," said Sandeep. It is still an evolving technology standard. Besides, each of these tools are meant for different things. So in the future you'll see a proper position for each of these. It's more likely to work in conjunction. "Take for instance YouTube – They're thinking of HTML5, but they believe it'll be five years till they completely move to it. The kind of control you get over video with flash – the way they've built it – be it full screen, scrolling, encapsulated embedding etc – is something that Flash

does so much better," Sandeep adds.

Himanshu (Tekho Point) seconds this sentiment. "The kind of enterprise level apps (with security) and rapid development using Adobe tools is something unique to Flash. In the long term HTML5 and Flash will be complementary. There will be some places where it would be beneficial to use Flash and at others HTML5. As a designer or developer you have a freedom of choice. You keep in mind your client's objectives and choose the technology accordingly. I won't be surprised if from a tool perspective, a Flash developer makes something in Flash and in future they're allowed to simply export it in HTML5, so that they can skip the learning curve completely" he

goes on to add. What about the gaming industry? Robin Alter CTO Kreeda, says, "Nurturing the developer community is important and so is nurturing the publisher. Publishers

generally support one technology for their games. HTML5 and Flash may actually be pretty complimentary so you may be able to use both" As for the question of being able to transition the answer is pretty simple. Yes transitioning, if at all needed, is not that difficult. Both technologies are based on similar programming principles. For all these languages have the same object oriented programming elements. If you're coding in Flash you write in ActionScript and do the styling in CSS. If on Flex you'll use MXML. Similar kind of concept exists on HTML5. Your code might contain JavaScript, and it'll definitely contain CSS style sheet. You'll still be using the same technologies in a different way, so it's not really a transition. You just need to make yourself aware of newer concepts like HGML where you can do 3D images, and you should be set.

So to conclude, since so many industry experts we spoke to believe in a coexistence perhaps it would be beneficial to dabble in both technologies. Diversification after all can only add value. Who knows, maybe in five years you might be one of those rare and sought after Flash + HTML5 professionals who can slice through code with a double edged sword. ■